RUTGERS

Pragmatics II

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2026/11/04 (updated: 2026-10-31)

Please pick up your **name card** from the front

office hours: Mondays, 2:00-3:00 pm

Basement, Room 003, **Linguistics Building**

Previously on 201: Grice's Maxims



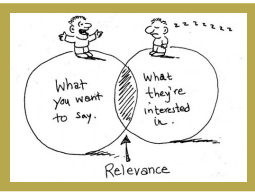
Maxim of Quality
be truthful

- don't say what you believe to be false
- don't say what you don't have evidence for



Maxim of Quantity
be informative as needed

- don't say more than you need to
- don't say less than you need to



Maxim of Relation (Relevance)
be relevant

- don't say irrelevant things



Maxim of Manner
be clear

- don't be obscure, ambiguous or wordy
- provide information in a **sensible** order

although they're worded like commands, the maxims are intended to describe how people **tend** to behave or are **assumed** to behave, not how they **ought to** behave

Previously on 201: Cancelling Implicatures

- what if we say the following sentence:

  Anna speaks English, Korean, and Farsi. ***In fact, she also speaks Greek***.

- implicatures can be **cancelled** or **defeated**: we add extra information to the statement that **contradicts** the **implicature** and makes it go away

- – *Anna speaks English, Korean, and Farsi*. *In fact, she also speaks Greek*.
  - ***implicature***: ~~*Anna speaks only these three languages*~~.

- – *Ian ate a cake and was happy*. *In fact, he ate the cake because he was happy*.
  - ***implicature***: ~~*Ian ate a cake and that made him happy*~~.

- – *Does Sue have any siblings?*.
  – *Sue has a brother*. *In fact, she has two brothers*.
  - ***implicature***: ~~*Sue has only one brother*~~.

Previously on 201: Reinforcing Implicatures

- what if we say the following sentence:

  Anna speaks English, Korean, and Farsi. ***And she doesn't speak any others***.

- implicatures can be **reinforced** as well: we add extra information to the statement that **further supports** the **implicature** and makes it firmer

- – *Anna speaks English, Korean, and Farsi*. *And she doesn't speak any others*.
  - ***implicature***: *Anna speaks only these three languages*. ✔

- – *Ian ate a cake and was happy*. *It was the cake that made him happy*.
  - ***implicature***: *Ian ate a cake and that made him happy*. ✔

- – *Does Sue have any siblings?*.
  – *Sue has a brother*, *and only one brother*.
  - ***implicature***: *Sue has only one brother*. ✔

Presupposition Revisit

Presuppositions

The king of England had lunch.

⬇

[[King of England]] ∈ [[had lunch]]

- mentions a **person**: the king of England
- mentions an **action**: had lunch
- state a **proposition** involving the person and the action

The king of New Jersey had lunch.

⬇

[[king of New Jersey]] ∈ [[had lunch]]

- mentions a **person**: the king of New Jersey
- mentions an **action**: had lunch
- state a **proposition** involving the person and the action

Presuppositions

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[[King of England]] ∈ [[had lunch]]

- mentions a **person**: the king of England
- mentions an **action**: had lunch
- state a **proposition** involving the person and the action

The king of New Jersey had lunch.

⬇

[[king of New Jersey]] ∈ [[had lunch]]

- mentions a **person**: the king of New Jersey
- mentions an **action**: had lunch
- state a **proposition** involving the person and the action

both sentences are declarative, only two **different** entities doing the **same** action

yet, the *king of New Jersey* does not exist

how can we make sense of the proposition if it involves **someone who doesn't exist**?

Presuppositions

- these two sentences have the same **presupposition**

(a) *The king of England had lunch*. (b) *The king of New Jersey had lunch*.

- in order to make sense of each, we have to assume **the person each refers to** exists:

- *The king of England had lunch.* **presupposes** that someone exists called king of England
- not a problem if we put it in our **real world**, since there **IS** this *king of England*

- *The king of New Jersey had lunch.* **presupposes** that someone exists called king of New Jersey
- this is a problem if we put it in our **real world**, since there exists **NO** such a *king of New Jersey*, and it's what makes this sentence odd

- a **presupposition** is information that must be **assumed** in order to make sense of an **utterance**

Presuppositions

- previously, we have said that it is a **special type** of entailment
- but we only discussed half of this issue
- in fact, presupposition is a **special type** only when we consider the **truth value**
- entailments are propositions that must be true in order for some other proposition to be true
- but they're not the same, because entailments rely on **truth values** only, and presuppositions are also about **making sense of** an utterance



Presuppositions

(a) *Snoopy is a beagle*.

(b) *Snoopy is a dog*.

(a) **entails** (b), if (a) is true, then (b) must be true

(c) *It is not the case that Snoopy is a beagle*.

- entailment is gone - (c) does **NOT** entail (b)
- but presupposition holds - Snoopy still exists

- presuppositions do **NOT** rely on truth values **only**

HOW TO DO NEGATION

Family of Sentences

- previously in **Semantics**, we sait that a **presupposes** b iff both a and *neg*-a entails b
- that is in fact to say **presuppositions** hold under **negation**
- actually **questioning** can do the same thing, which gives us a way to test whether a given idea is a **presupposition** or part of a sentence's **truth value**
- a **declarative sentence**, together with its and **negation** and **questioning** forms the **family of sentences**
  - any presuppositions will hold up – we still have to assume them to **make sense**
  - any propositions (ideas that are part of the sentence's **truth value**) will not

sentence type	**sentence**	**proposition (*he had lunch*)**	**presupposition (*king of NJ exists*)**
declarative	*The king of NJ ate lunch.*	asserted	assumed
negation	*The king of NJ didn't eat lunch.*	denied	assumed
question	*Did the king of NJ eat lunch?*	questioned	assumed

Common Ground

The authenticity of a statement in pure Sementics layer:



The authenticity of a statement in the Pragmatics layer:



presuppositions interact with a pragmatic concept known as the **common ground**

common ground is the information shared by all participants in a conversation

- basic info about the current situation
  - participants, event, venue/time
- information being discussed
- previous experience shared by participants
  - *Last night was fun!*
- general information about the world
  - *Merlin is a sorcerer.*

essentially, all the information I know and you know and I know that you know as the interlocutors

Common Ground

- we are constantly updating the **common ground** with **new information** as we talk
- it is like story-telling, things are added to the **common ground** along the telling

conversation	common ground
1. *I have a friend named Lancelot*.	
2. *Lancelot has a dog*.	
3. *Last night Lancelot ordered a pizza*.	
4. *Lancelot went into the kitchen to get a drink*.	
5. *When he came back, his dog had eaten the whole pizza*.	

Common Ground

- we are constantly updating the **common ground** with **new information** as we talk
- it is like story-telling, things are added to the **common ground** along the telling

conversation	common ground
1. *I have a friend named Lancelot*.	*Lancelot*
2. *Lancelot has a dog*.	*Lancelot, Lancelot's dog*
3. *Last night Lancelot ordered a pizza*.	*Lancelot, Lancelot's dog, the pizzaLancelot ordered*
4. *Lancelot went into the kitchen to get a drink*.	*Lancelot, Lancelot's dog, the pizza Lancelot ordered, Lancelot went to the kitchen*
5. *When he came back, his dog had eaten the whole pizza*.	• utterance **makes sense** because it relies on all of the info in the **common ground**

Common Ground

- information needs to be mentioned **in steps**, and they are gradually in the **common ground**
- once it is in the common ground, we can **refer back** to it
- information that is **NOT** yet in the common ground will **confuse** other participants in the conversation
- without any background information clarification
    - A: *When he came back, his dog had eaten the whole pizza!*
    - B: *Wait, what?!*



Presuppositions and the Common Ground

- what presuppositions do is not just **assume** information – they **assume that information is in the common ground**

The king of England took a nap.

- ➡️ **presupposes**: the king of England exists.
    - both speaker and listener are aware of this – which is **true**, so we can **accept** the sentence as meaningful

The king of New Jersey took a nap.

- ➡️ **presupposes**: the king of New Jersey exists.
    - both speaker and listener are aware he exists – which is **not true**, so we **cannot accept** the sentence as meaningful]

Presupposition Triggers

definite expressions | iteratives | change-of-state verbs | factive verbs | clefts

- **definite expressions** presuppose **something exists** and is in our common ground (existence presuppositions)

expression	example sentence	presupposition
definite article: *the*	*I saw a cat.* ***The cat*** *was fuzzy.*	a unique cat exists
definite pronouns: *I, you, she...*	***He*** *is a good student.*	a unique male person exists
demonstratives: *this, that*	*Pass me* ***that bottle****.*	a unique bottle exists
possessives: *my, our, their, Jane's*	***Jane's dog*** *is friendly.*	Jane has a dog
proper nouns: *Peter, Jane, Snoopy*	***Peter*** *called yesterday.*	a unique person named Peter exists

Presupposition Triggers

- **iterative expressions** presuppose the **repetition** of some action or state
- *again*, *too*, *either*, *return*, *come back*, *restore*, *more*, *less*

utterance	presupposition
*Sally baked a cake **again**.*	Sally has **previously** baked a cake.
*John **returned**.*	John was **previously** here.
*I want **more** cake.*	I **previously** had some cake.
*Sam **restored** the watch.*	The watch was **previously** in good repair.

Presupposition Triggers

- **change-of-state verbs** presuppose an action was **ongoing (or not ongoing) prior to** the moment in question
- *stop*, *start*, *begin*, *continue*, *keep*

utterance	presupposition
*Sally **stopped** baking.*	Sally was **previously** baking.
*I **started** singing.*	I was not **previously** singing.
*Pablo **kept** working.*	Pablo was **previously** working.

Presupposition Triggers

- **factive verbs** are verbs that refer to someone's **knowledge of** or **opinion about** some fact
- *know*, *realize*, *regret*, *be aware of*, *be glad that*, *be sorry that*
- they introduce a **dependent clause** containing the information **the subject** knows or has an opinion about
- this information is **presupposed**, since we can't know something if it's false

sample sentence	presupposition (dep clause)	proposition (main clause)
*I **know** that you studied.*	You studied.	I know **it**.
*Sally **is happy** that she bought a book.*	Sally bought a book	Sally is happy about **it**.
*Linda **regrets** sending the letter.*	Linda sent the letter.	Linda regrets **it**.
*Yuri **realized** that it was late.*	It was late.	Yuri realized **it**.

- test with the **family of sentences**
  - ***It is not the case that*** *Linda regrets sending the letter.*
  - ***Does*** *Linda regret sending the letter?*

Presupposition Triggers

- **clefts** are complex sentences formed by taking a simple sentence and putting part of it into a **dependent clause** as shown below

X Y'ed ➔	It was X that Y'ed.	What Y'ed was X.	X was who Y'ed.

- the **main clause** indicates the sentence's **claim**
- the information that has been moved to the **dependent clause** is **presupposed**

simple sentence	cleft sentence	presupposition	proposition (main clause)
John ate the pie.	***It was John** that ate the pie.*	*Someone ate the pie.*	*That person was John.*
Sally bought a souvenir.	*What Sally bought **was a souvenir**.*	*Sally bought something.*	*That thing was a souvenir.*
I saw Alice.	***Alice was** who I saw.*	*I saw someone.*	*That person was Alice.*

- test with the **family of sentences**
  - ***It was not the case that** what Sally bought was a souvenir.*
  - *Is what Sally bought a souvenir*

Exercise I: Presupposition

- identify any **definite expressions** and state the existence presuppositions they raise
- identify any **other presupposition trigger** and state the presuppositions they raise

(a) *I took my dog for a walk again.*

(b) *It was Emily that ate the cookie.*

(c) *Juliana found out that Toby had returned.*

(d) *Eli wants more popcorn.*

(e) *The elephant will continue to be endangered until we stop destroying its natural habitat.*

Exercise I: Presupposition

- identify any **definite expressions** and state the existence presuppositions they raise
- identify any **other presupposition trigger** and state the presuppositions they raise

(a) *I took my dog for a walk again.*

I, my dog

(b) *It was Emily that ate the cookie.*

Emily, the cookie

(c) *Juliana found out that Toby had returned.*

Juliana, Toby

(d) *Eli wants more popcorn.*

Eli

(e) *The elephant will continue to be endangered until we stop destroying its natural habitat.*

the elephant,
its natural habitat

Exercise I: Presupposition

- identify any **definite expressions** and state the existence presuppositions they raise
- identify any **other presupposition trigger** and state the presuppositions they raise

(a) *I took my dog for a walk again.*

I, my dog — **again** (iterative) – I previously took my dog for a walk.

(b) *It was Emily that ate the cookie.*

Emily, the cookie — **it was X that Y** (cleft) – Someone ate the cookie.

(c) *Juliana found out that Toby had returned.*

Juliana, Toby — **found out** (factive) – Toby had in fact returned.
returned (iterative) – Toby was previously there.

(d) *Eli wants more popcorn.*

Eli — **more** (iterative) – Eli previously had popcorn.

(e) *The elephant will continue to be endangered until we stop destroying its natural habitat.*

the elephant, — **continue** (CoS) – The elephant was previously endangered.
its natural habitat — **stop** (CoS) – We were previously destroying its habitat.

Presupposition Accommodation and Failure

- presuppositions **assume that something is in the common ground**

  The king of England took a nap.

- ➡️ **presupposes**: *England has a king.*
  - it is in our common ground and it **makes sense**

- what if a presupposition assumes something that is **NOT** actually in our common ground?

  The king of New Jersey took a nap.

- ➡️ **presupposes**: *New Jersey has a king.*
  - it's NOT in our common ground

- we either **accommodate to** or **dispute on** the presupposition
  - presupposition **accommodation**
  - presupposition **failure**



Presupposition Accommodation

accommodating a presupposition: assuming (or at least pretending) that a presupposition is **true** in order to **make sense** out of the utterance

I need to pick up my dragon from the vet.

- ➡️ **presupposes** *I have a dragon.*

that's not in the common ground, but can be **accommodated** - assuming that **I do have a dragon** which is reasonable if you know I am **MERLIN** and it doesn't conflict with your knowledge of the **fantasy** world

- by **accommodating** the presupposition, I am allowing it to be added to the **common ground**
- now I can say something further about **"him"** (the dragon)
- you know who I'm talking about, because you've **allowed** *my dragon* to be added to the **common ground**]

Presupposition Failure

sometimes a presupposition is **harder to accommodate**

the Martian in our class is going to give a presentation.

- ➡️ **presupposes** *There is a Martian in our class.*
- this is harder to accommodate so it leads to **presupposition failure**
- the result is the utterance **doesn't make sense**
- it's not that the sentence is **true or false**, it's just **nonsensical**
- if I say you're lying or that's false, I'm denying the claim, **NOT** the presupposition
- to deny the presupposition, we would have to say something like
  - *There cannot be Martian in the class.*



Presuppositions and Misleading Language

- because presupposition failure leads to a breakdown in communication but we do want our conversation to go on, so
- **we have a tendency to accommodate to presuppositions**
- sometimes people take advantage of this property and trick others to **accomodate to the presupposition**

- **in the court room, the lawyer asked a defendant**
  - *Have you stopped embezzling money?*
  - *Yes or no?*
- what is the lawyer **presupposing**?
- can the defendant answer **without looking guilty**?

- **in the restaurant, someone asked their boyfriend**
  - *Has she always liked it here as well*?
- what is this someone **presupposing**?
- what would probably be after this boyfriend **answers yes or no**?

Presuppositions and Misleading Language

- **clickbait headlines**, **advertisements**, and other persuasive language sometimes uses **presuppositions** to influence people:

- *what local dad found will surprise you!*
  - proposition: X will surprise you
  - presuppositions: local dad found something worth knowing about

- the author's goal here is to get the reader to accept the **presupposition** by accommodating it without questioning it directly
  - because we figure out **presupposition** so unintentionally

- in each **clickbait** headline to the right, identify at least one **presupposition** and its trigger

1. *Why You Should Create a Vision Board for 2024*
2. *Why You Should Ditch the 'Diet' and Go Keto Instead*
3. *You Won't Believe This Dog's Dance Moves!*
4. *Did You Know HOW Healthy Mushrooms Are for Your Brain?*
5. *This is How Designers Can Make More Money With Fewer Clients*
6. *This Is Why Business Owners are Investing in Bitcoin*

Assignment V is due this Friday (**Nov 06**) at **11:59 pm**

Assignment VI will be published this Wednesday (**Nov 04**) and is due next Friday (**Nov 13**) at **11:59 pm**

reading: Michael Dobrovolsky's chapter **Phonetics**
(from O'Grady et al.'s *Contemporary Linguistics: An Introduction*



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